

FORZA HORIZON 5



VIVA LA MEXICO!

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The Forza Horizon series has always been the pinnacle of arcade racing for the last decade. Each new instalment in the series has raised the bar. With Forza Horizon 5, developer Playground Games has set its eyes on continuing that trend. Forza Horizon 4 already raised the bar pretty high. Will Forza Horizon 5 manage to reach those lofty heights? Yes... Yes, it does.

GRAPHICS: OOH... SHINY...

We played Forza Horizon 5 on the Xbox Series X and it looks absolutely gorgeous. This is possibly the best-looking racing game we have played and helps to best showcase the possibilities on offer with Microsoft's new console.

The cars as well as the landscapes are incredibly detailed. The way dirt, dust and water react to your car is incredible. Just driving through the

desert, your car will be covered in dust. Bombing through the jungle will leave your tires caked in mud. A quick dip in the water will leave your car all shiny again. While the game does not feature a complete damage mode, crashes will leave your ride with cracked windshields, and dented bodywork.

The best part is that this graphical fidelity does not come at the cost of performance. The game does offer you a choice between performance or graphics at the start. We chose to play the game in graphics mode and we didn't really feel any noticeable drop in frame rates or such.

Interestingly, taking pictures via the game's built-in photo mode really takes things up a notch. While the game does not offer ray tracing during gameplay, it turns it on during Photo Mode and the Forzavista mode. This lets you really appreciate the hard work Playground Games did. It also lets you take some pretty stunning shots, which is something the developers wanted you to do. Photo Mode is turned on the moment

you press 'up' on the D-pad, letting you freeze the action and take your time in crafting the perfect shot.

SETTING: MUY BUENO AMIGO

The setting in a Forza Horizon game is usually just as big a star as the cars. Thankfully, the choice of Mexico is excellent. Of course, the map isn't an accurate representation of the country, but more than a 'best of' collection of some of the more notable locations in the country.

The swathes of sand towards the west allow for some Baja racing action, while the tropical rainforests in the south are ideal for some cross-country action. The central area features a large desert complete with giant cacti. There are also cities that allow for some tight street racing action. Up north is a giant mountain that truly lets you take in the sheer scale of the map.

STORY AND GAMEPLAY: THE STANDARD HORIZON EXPERIENCE

The story is pretty straightforward and we're quite grateful for that. We don't want our racing game to feature